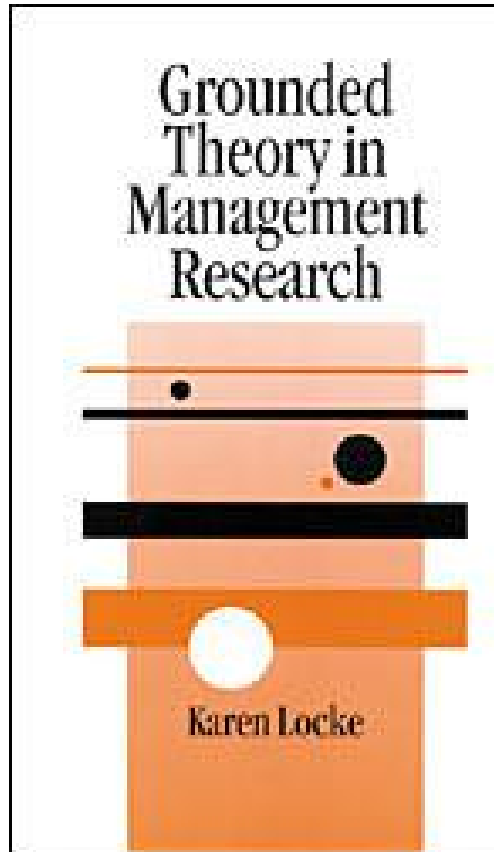




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Introduction

Pick up and read any qualitative research article in the domain of management and organization studies, and the chances are very high that you will find a citation to Glaser and Strauss (1967). Their work, *The Discovery of Grounded Theory*, is a familiar landmark to most organization scholars who perform and/or who read qualitative studies. Perhaps because the book is widely cited, it is through the idea of grounded theory that many quantitatively trained researchers gain their introduction to qualitative methods. But, why should there be a book about it?

First, during graduate school, exposure to the procedural details of grounded theory is limited. While formal coursework in qualitative methods is increasingly appearing in Ph.D. programs in organization and management, it is still the case that many graduate students do not have access to training in qualitative methods and to focused course-work on the grounded theory approach. Similarly, compared with quantitative approaches, there are few faculty members in departments of organization and management who have pursued qualitative research in general and the grounded theory style in particular. There are also few qualitative management and organization scholars (myself included) who have been exposed to either of the originators, Barney Glaser or Anselm Strauss, or to any of their students, as a research mentor. This means that, although grounded theory as a qualitative research approach is quite visible in organization and management studies, there are limited opportunities during graduate training for in depth exploration of its research logic and procedures.

Second, citing practices indicate that organization and management scholars may not be aware of the full scope of grounded theory resources available to them. For example, methodological discussions of the grounded theory approach by the originators have appeared intermittently over a more than 30-year time period, yet, as I have pointed out elsewhere (Locke, 1997), the original 1967 monograph is often the only methodological reference to appear. In a more recent twist, Strauss and Corbin's (1990, 1998) more formulaic account is appearing as the single methodological reference to grounded theory. Other works by the originators do not seem to be considered. Related to this, resources for conducting grounded theory are spread across a number of domains, for example, sociology, nursing, education and psychology, making it difficult for organization and management scholars to track them down.

Third, as approaches and ideas are taken from one domain and put to use in another, they undergo transformation; this has been the case with grounded theory. As I shall discuss in the book, it appears that

many management and organization researchers have selectively taken up grounded theory's logic and procedures, adapting and integrating them with the logic and practices from other qualitative analytic styles. To a degree, its informing logic and operational practices appear to have fractured as they have been adapted to the purposes and constraints of specific research situations and have been blended with other procedures. Certainly, the school of thought, namely symbolic interactionism, that informed the understanding of social reality expressed in grounded theory's research practices, appears to have been left behind.

In summary, even though the grounded theory approach to qualitative research is apparent through its being widely cited, the scope of work that comprises the relevant body of methodological work is, in large part, invisible. My impetus for writing this book is to restore and reveal more fully the grounded theory approach in organization and management studies. I imagine you, the readers, as graduate students and others who are interested in conducting qualitative studies of organizational and managerial life and who want to learn more about the grounded theory style of qualitative research. The creative theory building purposes of the approach are broadly appealing to many researchers whose introduction to research methods in professional schools (and the business school is certainly in that category) has strongly emphasized a logico-deductive approach executed through quantitative analytic tools. I expect that this book will be useful to those of you interested in exploring this dimension of research but who have had little exposure to grounded theory, except as a citation in publications. It will also be useful to those of you who perhaps have read one or two methodological discussions of it but have not explored the approach further. More seasoned researchers who are also interested in grounded theory but who have had little exposure to qualitative research approaches in general or this research style in particular will also find it useful.

This book, then, attempts to restore the grounded theory style of qualitative research, especially in and for scholars of organizations and management. I have borrowed the idea of restoration from Susan Leigh Star (1991), a student of one of the originators, Anselm Strauss. She characterizes the central theme in Strauss's scholarship as making visible all the work that goes into maintaining the realities of work and life that we take for granted. For the purposes of this book, restoring is interpreted in two ways. First, it involves detailing the disciplinary school of thought and procedural details of the grounded theory approach as they have been articulated by the originators, their students, and by scholars in other disciplines, including organization and management studies over the past 30 years. Second, it involves describing and discussing the use of grounded theory in studies of organization and management over the same time period. By pulling together in one place the broadly dispersed discussions of grounded theory's logic and practices in sociology, in nursing research, in education, in psychology, and also in organization and management studies, I hope to restore

and reveal more fully much of the work that has gone into articulating this qualitative approach. I also hope to more fully disclose the analytic and personal work that building grounded theory requires. Similarly, by describing grounded theory in organization and management studies, including the phenomena that have been investigated, the translations of the approach's logic and procedures, and the written products that constitute grounded theories, I hope to more fully reveal the possibilities and challenges of the approach for this domain.

Organization of chapters

This book is organized into three parts. Part One of the book aims to reveal several important features of the context for the grounded theory style of qualitative research. One way to distinguish qualitative researchers is by their interest in context. We believe that it is impossible to comprehend fully a phenomenon without understanding the context in which it is expressed. Chapter 1 begins by describing the historical development of qualitative research; it explains the various paradigms of inquiry in which qualitative researchers work, locating the grounded theory approach within them. It concludes by describing other styles of qualitative research that are popular with organization and management researchers with which grounded theory co-exists. Chapter 2 continues the focus on context, taking a more disciplinary point of view. It introduces American pragmatism and the symbolic interactionist school of thought that inform this approach; it describes the sociological context in which grounded theory was articulated, and it reveals a little of the personal biographies of its originating authors. From this, I hope that readers will be able gain a sense of the history and domain of qualitative research in general (and of the organization and management area in particular), appreciating grounded theory's place in it. Further, I hope that they gain understanding of the relationship between the character of the grounded theory style of research and the features of time and its disciplinary context.

Part Two is concerned with the research approach itself. Before explicating the operational details of the approach, Chapter 3 first outlines some of its distinguishing features and clarifies the kinds of theoretical outcome grounded theory building is intended to achieve. It also introduces readers to the language terms used to speak about such theories. Chapter 4 focuses on the research logic and basic operational procedures as they were initially articulated. It details the processes through which meaning is assigned to qualitative data and data sampling is executed. It also provides some of the criteria by which grounded theories are

evaluated. Chapter 5 brings Part Two to a close by delineating procedural developments in grounded theory analysis that have followed during the last 30 years (including divergence in these developments on the part of the originators), and by considering some of the personal tensions researchers face when they execute this research approach. I hope that readers will take away from this section a basic understanding of the procedures of grounded theory. Of course, while important, this understanding is nothing without researcher experience. Researchers will have to embark on their own grounded theory studies, breathing life into the words through which the procedures are described with the details of their own experience. I also hope that readers will seek out and draw on the many methodological discussions referenced, deepening their understanding of the approach.

Part Three moves more fully into revealing grounded theory in the domain of organization and management studies, examining how it has traveled and been translated as it has been adopted and adapted here. The particular features of grounded theory building that make it suitable for studies in our domain are suggested in Chapter 6. It also describes and demonstrates how grounded theory has been adopted, and it details the ways in which management researchers have adapted it, integrating new procedures and orienting schools of thought into the approach. The kinds of theory organization and management researchers have developed are illustrated, and Chapter 6 closes by considering possible constraints that the study of corporate organizations and management might impose on grounded theory procedures. Chapter 7 examines grounded theory in studies of organization and management as a composed research product. Here the book pays particular attention to the crafting of a grounded theory journal article. It describes the character of grounded theories in management and organization studies and examines how they are textually presented. I hope that readers will take from Part Three a sense of the challenges and opportunities associated with using this style of research, and that they will be inspired by the breadth and variety of published work that has drawn on it.

A note on the perspective of the author

Before concluding this introduction, a final note on the perspective I bring to this project and to methodological accounts in general. I began qualitative studies as an undergraduate when working with a group of ethologists. I learned to make systematic and detailed observations that were then converted into frequency data - very much in the tradition of more modernist content analysis practiced today. I came later in graduate work to the issue of meaning and interpretation, and have since adopted an interpretive perspective in my

work. With the focus this perspective provides on how realities are constructed, I am aware of the constructed character of methodological accounts. Descriptions of particular methods of research obviously take place as retrospective accounts. They are reports written after the bulk of research practices have been concluded, rather than being narrated moment by moment within the stream of acts that comprise the research method in-use (Vidich and Lyman, 1994, p. 24). As such, they condense what was originally experienced into a set of coherent images that often omit much of the *ad hoc*, opportunistic, and problem solving nature of the inquiry process. KnorrCetina's work (1981) that provides a description of how research chemists, for example, fashion a textually linear account out of a nonlinear research process as they prepare their work for formal publication highlights this. Specifically, it brings out the discrepancies between the coherence articulated in representations of research processes and the disjointedness of research as an act in progress.

Furthermore, the disembodied, general and technical language displayed by such texts conforms very closely to the rhetoric traditionally associated with all 'scientific writing' (Golden-Biddle and Locke, 1997; Selzer, 1993). The language and the research processes they describe easily take on the form of textbook ideals (Vidich and Lyman, 1994).

I have made some deliberate choices in writing this book to highlight the constructed character of our research efforts. The decision to devote a whole part of the book to grounded theory's historical, disciplinary context and to include the biographies of the originators was made *not* to write the procedures as disembodied, impersonal, and a-historical, but to place them in a time, location, and in particular 'bodies.' I have also made some deliberate choices in the language that I use to describe the research process. Specifically, when talking about analysis, I have chosen to use wording that highlights the agency of researchers who actively compose their analytic categories and research findings. This contrasts with the language of the originators, so prevalent at the time in which they wrote their monograph, which suggests a more passive role in which some external reality might be 'discovered' by application of the appropriate procedures. And, I have chosen to reveal my own agency in writing this text.

Situating the Discovery of Grounded Theory Within the Tradition of Qualitative Methods

In 1967 Barney Glaser and Anselm Strauss published *The Discovery of Grounded Theory*. It was their formal description of the approach to handling and interpreting qualitative data that they had developed in the early 1960s during what is described as a participant observation study of hospital staff's care and management of dying patients. As originally stated, they characterize this research approach as one oriented towards the inductive generation of theory from data that has been systematically obtained and analyzed (Glaser and Strauss, 1967). Some 30+ years have passed since the publication of that monograph. During this time, the general approach to qualitative data analysis and theory development articulated in that volume has both persisted and been taken up in disciplines outside its originating domain of sociology. The grounded theory style of qualitative research has traveled extensively, for example, to psychology, to information science, to education, to many communities of practice within health care, and, of course, to management and organization studies. Indeed, in the domain of qualitative research, the original text has assumed canonical status. Norman Denzin, one of the editors of the widely read and cited *Handbook of Qualitative Research*, underscores the status of this approach to qualitative research with the startling statement that 'the grounded theory perspective is the most widely used qualitative interpretive framework in the social sciences today' (1994: 508). He takes his point even further, noting that 'when one peels back the layers of discourse embedded in any of the numerous qualitative guides to interpretation and theory construction, the core features of the Strauss approach are present, even when Strauss and associates are not directly named' (1994: 513).

Interestingly, despite the visibility and status of the *Discovery* book, at this point in time, just what constitutes grounded theory is by no means an unequivocal or an uncontested issue. As I shall discuss in more detail a little later, grounded theory has evolved and adapted as its research practices have been further articulated and extended by its originators, their students, and other methodologists who have taken up this style of inquiry. In addition, those substantive researchers who have found its guidance useful and who have adapted and incorporated it into their own work have further interpreted its research practices. By the late 1980s and early 1990s, the nature of grounded theorizing became an issue, and it was being explicitly contested by the originators of the approach and their respective students (Glaser, 1992; Locke, 1997; Stern, 1994; Strauss and Corbin, 1990).

What I should like to do in Part One of this book, by way of an introduction to the analytic research practices and conceptual products indicated by the term 'grounded theory,' is to provide some background and context for this research approach before moving on, **in** Part Two, to outline the research process as it was initially articulated. It makes sense to begin, I think, with the perspective afforded by a number of different but interrelated histories. These are: the research tradition that falls under the rubric of qualitative methods; the disciplinary domain of sociology, particularly the symbolic interactionist tradition and its informing American pragmatist philosophy; and, of course, the personal biographies of the original monograph's authors. For, as Denzin & Lincoln (1994) suggest, behind any work stand the personal biographies of culturally and historically situated researchers. Typically, grounded theory's 'origination story' represents it as being developed and articulated within the context of a particular research program on dying in medical institutions that was carried out in northern California over a six-year period **in** the late 1950s and early 1960s. However, this research approach is also a product of the authors' location within a community of research practice, a particular disciplinary tradition, and, of course, their particular biographies within both at a particular moment in time. All three histories guided and shaped *The Discovery of Grounded Theory*.

These discussions will provide a foundation for understanding the character of grounded theory both as a research process and as a particular research product. Of course, the stories of contexts and histories that follow are similarly situated ones, and they express a coherence that I am composing in grounded theory's intellectual tradition, its research practices and the personal biographies of its originators. Here **in** Chapter 1, I sketch the domain of qualitative research and grounded theory's place in it by first providing one perspective on qualitative research's development over the last 90 years. **In** doing this, I underscore the methodological issues that absorbed researcher attention during the various stages of its history. The chapter then considers the different research paradigms in which these same issues find current expression in the qualitative study of organization and management. This introduction to the domain of qualitative research closes by reviewing several other styles of qualitative research practice with which grounded theory coexists.

A historical perspective on the practice of qualitative methods

Moments in the development of qualitative research

The beginning of qualitative research methods as professionally established practices for generating knowledge in the human disciplines is often located in the early 1900s within two social science domains: sociology, with the 'Chicago School's' qualitative approach to the study of group life, and anthropology, with the tradition of fieldwork established by such notables as Bateson, Boaz, Evans-Pritchard, Radcliffe-Brown and Malinowski (Denzin and Lincoln, 1994). (I should note that this representation of these disciplines as discrete is somewhat misleading, because up until the 1950s they were often practiced within the same University department under one administrator (Van Maanen, 1988)). In these disciplines at this time, modern social science researchers were concerned with producing valid and objective interpretations of social groups studied through field based qualitative procedures.

In the 90 or so years since those beginnings, Denzin and Lincoln (1994) outline what they term five moments of qualitative research practice. These moments are: the traditional, the modernist, the moment of blurred genres, the crisis of representation, and the double crisis. Each of these moments represents a period of time in which a discernible set of issues and considerations became evident in the field of qualitative research. The issues and considerations that arose in them highlight different perspectives on knowledge, the role of the researcher in making it, and the language through which such knowledge is presented. Consequently they affected the way that researchers within the qualitative tradition practiced, understood, reflected on, and wrote about their craft. Although each of these moments is associated with a particular point of time during the recent 90 years, the view of research practice expressed in each of them persists and still operates into the present. The result is that qualitative research today is a practice domain populated by many viewpoints and styles of practice.

Denzin and Lincoln (1994) identify that first moment when fieldwork became professionally established in sociology and anthropology as the 'traditional' moment. In sociology (in the United States, at least), this moment is often marked by the initial publication in 1918 of Thomas and Znaniecki's *The Polish Peasant in Europe and America*. This was a monumental fieldwork-based and theoretically oriented empirical effort whose com-

posed results ran to well over two thousand pages. One of its authors, W.I. Thomas, was influential at the University of Chicago, as was Robert E. Park. Under the latter's direction, the 'Chicago School,' as it came to be called, was responsible for producing a set of ethnographic studies that focused on particularized descriptions of various aspects of human life that they perceived to be emerging in the city (Vidich and Lyman, 1994).

While qualitative sociologists, especially Chicago sociologists, were out studying life near to home, their disciplinary siblings in anthropology went abroad to conduct first hand extended field studies of 'other' races and cultures of the world and to bring back accounts of their lives. Bronislaw Malinowski's *Argonauts of the Western Pacific* (1922) is regarded by many as the quintessential anthropological ethnography of this moment. Similarly, Margaret Mead's (1928) account of life in Samoa provides a straightforward depiction of the lives of 'others' who live in distant lands. In both sociology and anthropology, the written knowledge products that resulted from these studies were taken to be real and accurate reports of the lives and worlds of their subjects. The role of researchers was as observer of the lives and worlds of the subject, and the language of their knowledge texts was viewed as providing a literal representation of those worlds.

The traditional moment was followed in the years after World War II by a second, 'modernist,' one that continued, and continues today, to embrace social realism. This modern moment celebrates researcher ability to accurately portray the social situation and subjects they study. Many management and organization scholars, particularly those with an interest in qualitative methods, will be familiar with the work of William Foote Whyte, whose accounts of Italian American life in 'Cornerville' (1955) demonstrate both their Chicago heritage and their commitment to a realist portrayal of life on the street. In this moment, the role of authors and the language through which they construct the social reality they studied continue to be taken for granted. Language is conceived as a tool that reflects discovered phenomena, and in this moment, researchers ask no questions about the agency of the researcher in producing knowledge about the social situation studied nor do they examine just what is being represented in the written products of their investigative efforts. This social realist perspective on writing and language, as Rorty (1982) points out, construes writing as an intermediary between these discovered phenomena and their portrayal in disciplinary texts such as the research monograph or journal article. In time, however, questions were raised about just what qualitative researchers had been taking for granted as they conducted their studies and composed their research products for publication.

The modernist moment was then, in its turn, followed in the 1970s and early 1980s by the moment of 'blurred

genres.' In this moment, the notions of social realism and objectivist knowledge were challenged, as many qualitative researchers embraced the position that knowledge making is fundamentally an act of interpretation. It was in this moment that qualitative research took its 'interpretive turn' (Rabinow and Sullivan, 1979: 1), highlighting among other things the role played by culture and context, including those of researchers, in the interpretation of human activity. Geertz' (1973) phrase 'blurred genres' similarly echoes interpretivism through the idea that distinctions between the social sciences and the humanities were no longer tenable. Consistent with this idea, questions were raised about the privileged status accorded to researchers' accounts of the situations they studied. From the vantage of this moment, language becomes a problematic issue; its ability to reflect reality is actively considered and challenged. Accordingly, research accounts are conceived as fundamentally interpretive rather than objective.

During the mid-1980s, this interpretive turn developed more fully. At this time, scholars directly challenged our modernist assumptions that there are 'real' social realities, subjects, and theories that can be veridically expressed through language (Cunliffe, 2000). Rather, language is understood to be a medium that can create only a particular view of reality. It takes on particular significance as the site where social realities are created because language defines both what we know about a situation and how we know it - it produces the very objects of which it speaks (Hardy and Palmer, 1999). Objectivity and its correspondence to reality were thus disputed, and the status of language shifted from being literal to being seen as metaphorical and constitutive of 'reality' (Cunliffe, 2000). This led to a re-examination of the role of researchers, the language of knowledge bearing texts, and to a concern with 'reflexivity.' The latter underscores the importance of reflecting on assumptions that we as researchers make when we produce what we regard as knowledge (Cunliffe, 2000; Hardy and Palmer, 1999).

Not surprisingly, from the vantage of this moment, the knowledge texts produced during earlier periods were viewed quite differently. For example, the work of the traditional and modernist moments was reconceived. While the knowledge texts of classical anthropologists like the ones mentioned continued to be studied for the stories they told about conducting and writing fieldwork (e.g. Wax, 1972), their representation of social worlds and subjects were strongly criticized for constituting them according to a colonial ethos (Rosaldo, 1989). Geertz (1988) drew attention to the authorial styles of particular anthropologists, underscoring how they portrayed those they studied. Within management and organization studies, Van Maanen (1988) explored 'realist' ethnographic tales for the ways in which their language constructs those 'real' realities of other people and worlds. While 'realist' texts were critiqued, researchers probed the possibility of more reflexive

writing. In some of these explorations, researchers attempt to disclose their agency by writing themselves into their knowledge texts (Van Maanen, 1988). In others, researchers set aside the traditional form of the scientific research monograph and experimented with a wide range of narrative forms and devices (see Ellis and Bochner, 1996; Richardson, 1995). A provocative example of writing knowledge differently is Marianne Paget's (1995) production of a performance text; yes, she performed the work.

The present fifth moment of 'double crisis' is characterized as a poststructural or postmodern one. The double crisis continues the previous moment's focus on representation, but it takes the concerns with representation further, challenging the possibility of ever establishing the realities of lived experience in the social scene studied or the identity and values of the researcher apart from the language through which both are represented. The moment of 'double crises' raises the possibility that knowledge can never be established or settled in any ultimate sense. From the vantage of this unsettling moment, there is no such thing as reality; reality is an image created by the language we use. Furthermore, there are multiple versions of such reality, none of which is more or less real than the other, though some versions are more privileged than others (Hardy and Palmer, 1999). During this moment, researchers increasingly became interested in the political dimensions of texts. The latter were viewed as mechanisms for creating and maintaining particular relations of power that gave voice to some while excluding others, and researchers understood their role as taking on the voice of those silenced others. During this moment, critical and feminist research approaches took hold.

While the issues and concerns recognized in each of these moments were initially articulated outside management and organization studies in domains such as anthropology, sociology and cultural studies, they of course have been taken up by qualitative researchers in management. Each of these moments finds expression in our own discipline where it is now commonplace to conceive and speak of qualitative research as falling within one of three paradigms: modern, interpretive and postmodern (Hatch, 1997). Guba and Lincoln (1994) build on Thomas Kuhn's (1970) ideas about paradigms as constellations of values, beliefs and methodological assumptions embedded in particular views of the world to compose the following definition. A paradigm is a set of basic beliefs about the nature of reality, the nature of the relationship between researchers and the worlds and subjects they study, and the methods through which knowledge can be achieved. As Guba and Lincoln point out, these 'beliefs are basic in the sense that they must be accepted simply on faith (however well argued); there is no way to establish their ultimate truthfulness' (1994: 107).

Roughly speaking, the second modernist moment corresponds to the realist stance of the modernist para-

digm; the third and fourth moments are incorporated within the interpretive paradigm; and the fifth moment of double crisis is consistent with postmodernism. Qualitative research is practiced by management and organization scholars from each of these paradigms across a number of communities of research practice. Let us briefly touch on these paradigms as well on some of the variety expressed in qualitative research practice.

Qualitative research paradigms in studies of management and organization

The modernist paradigm

The modernist paradigm continues the grand project begun around the time of Descartes to displace a dependency on faith as the source of knowledge with a reliance on reason. The modernist emphasis is on explanations of how the world works that ultimately could be harnessed towards its prediction and control. Accordingly, inquiry is directed towards the discovery of empirical facts and universal laws of cause and effect that are to be embedded in an explanatory or theoretical framework. Such abstract theoretical frameworks would clarify and integrate the facts and the laws that govern the way the world works, and would hold independent of time and context (Cuba and Lincoln, 1994).

Modernism assumes a realist ontology. It supposes that an objective world exists as a knowable observable reality and that the facts of and laws governing that world are given and independent of those who might observe them. This world is investigated primarily through a hypothetico-deductive method in which prior theory plays a primary role (Bryman, 1988). First, hypotheses about the way the world likely works are advanced; then they are tested against that world. In practice, this means that research in the modernist tradition is directed towards elaborating theories whose approximations to reality are composed in the form of *a priori* hypotheses that are verified or refuted against the referent of observed reality (Denzin and Lincoln, 1994). Knowledge consequently takes the form of substantiated propositions that can be accepted as facts or laws because they have been checked against reality. This perspective is illustrated in Ross and Staw's (1993) qualitative case study of the Shoreham nuclear power plant. In this study, Ross and Staw 'tested' a four-stage temporal model of organizational escalation that had been derived from prior work. In their words, the study of

Shoreham was designed to provide an 'independent test of Propositions 1 and 2' - elements of their temporal model of organizational escalation (1993: 703).

The modernist stance is also evident in the style of qualitative data analysis termed 'content analysis.' Some time ago, as an undergraduate in the psychology department of University College London, I rejected the instruction I had received in experimental design that had been my research preparation for an honors thesis in favor of a more direct and natural approach to research. (Obviously, my own commitments to research style surfaced quite early). Signing up with the small band of ethologists who occupied a corner of the department, my first qualitative project involved operational practices that are at the heart of content analysis. These are: detailed observations of social activity gathered via field work; the creation of conceptual categories; and the development of frequency counts of the occurrence of the conceptual categories in the field observations that enabled the quantitative testing of propositions.

Closer to the domain of management and organization studies, Richard Boyatsis drew on these practices in a study designed to determine which managerial characteristics were related to effective performance (1982). In one phase of the study, transcripts were developed from interviews during which respondents were asked to describe incidents of on-the-job effectiveness and ineffectiveness. A coding system was developed to analyze these interview based observations. Previous work provided the basis from which 19 conceptual categories that comprised this study's coding system were developed. The interview transcripts were independently coded by two coders for frequency of occurrence of each of the 19 categories. The frequencies determined for the conceptual categories then formed the basis for making comparisons of managers in high, average, and low performance groupings. The resulting correlations pointed to those characteristics that distinguished high from low performance.

As this brief illustration indicates, modernist qualitative researchers share with quantitative investigators a concern for the nature of the relationship between their discovered facts and the observable world that these purport to explain. Specifically, in order for these facts and relationships to earn their way into a broad theoretical framework, they must meet a number of criteria. Their appropriateness for inclusion is evaluated by the extent to which the researcher's findings accurately map the aspect of the social world studied (internal validity); the extent to which the findings hold for other social settings and actors that are similar to the one studied (generalizability); the extent to which the findings persist and are able to be reproduced (reliability); and the extent to which the findings are independent of and free from any bias (Guba and Lincoln, 1994).

In terms of qualitative research, these criteria are evident in a number of research practices. Given that qualitative researchers often focus on few cases, and therefore small sample sizes, they have generally made strong claims for the internal validity of their findings. Further, the issue of potential bias is often addressed through the use of multiple coders whose individual application of the codes can be compared. For example, Fox-Wolfgramm (1997) emphasizes the importance of achieving interrater reliability in analyses of qualitative data.

The interpretive paradigm

The interpretive (and related constructivist) paradigms are distinguished by an interest in understanding the world of lived experience from the point of view of those who live it. Their concern, therefore, is with a subjective reality. Researchers working in this paradigm focus on particular situated actors who they construe as composing meaning out of events and phenomena through prolonged processes of interaction that involve history, language and action. Thus, social reality is not a given. It is built up over time through shared history, experience and communication so that what is taken for 'reality' is what is shared and taken for granted as to the way the world is to be perceived and understood. Interpretive social research, then, focuses on what events and objects mean to people, on how they perceive what happens to them and around them, and on how they adapt their behavior in light of these meanings and perspectives (Rubin and Rubin, 1995). Because meaning is composed through situated interaction, the interpretive approach makes the assumption that meaning is not standardized from place to place or person to person. Interpretive researchers accept that values and views may well differ across groups and across social settings, and they appreciate that shared meaning is an achievement.

Interpretivists believe that in order to understand this world, researchers must engage with and participate in it, and they must actively interpret it. That is, to prepare an interpretation researchers must first participate in the social world in order to better understand it before they compose and offer their construction of the meaning systems of the social actors they study (Schwandt, 1994). Interpretive researchers, therefore, use methods like participant observation and ethnographic interviewing to try to elicit organization members' perspectives on the social worlds they live in, their work, and the events they observed or were party to.

This tradition obviously has an understanding of method that is inconsistent with the modernist concern with

discovering universally applicable laws or structuring principals to explain behavior and with the elimination of personal subjective judgment expressed in notions such as verification and testability. Rather than method being a tool that when followed eliminates human judgment, interpretivism conceives of method as a tool to assist judgment. Of course, there is a certain tension between the interpretivist's interest in the first-hand subjective experience of those they study and their equal interest in constructing an external, even objectified, account of that experience (Denzin, 1992). Researchers in this paradigm aim to make responsible interpretations and to provide solid bases for them. However, interpretivism takes for granted that researcher agency in formulating judgments cannot be eliminated, because social scientists are caught in the same human meaning making web as those that they study (Rabinow and Sullivan, 1979). Researchers consequently attempt to be 'up front' with their readers and 'confess' (Van Maanen, 1988) their values and interests.

Most organization scholars likely associate *The Social Construction of Reality* (Berger and Luckmann, 1967), written by sociologists, with this paradigm. Within organization studies, Hatch (1997) has argued that this interpretive tradition is expressed in Karl Weick's (1969) enactment theory, which underscores the active role that organization members play in creating the very organizations in which they work. Hatch (1997) suggests an interpretive view is expressed in two ways: first, in recognizing the constitutive nature of language so that by using ideas like organization we actively create it as phenomena; and second, by highlighting that what organizational actors take as being real is subjective. Other examples of interpretive work include: Gephart's (1978) study of organization succession that focuses on the language and activities through which succession is created; Isabella's (1990) study of middle managers in a financial services institution, underscoring that changes in managers' understanding and interpretations of organizational events are necessary in order for a change process to advance; Bartunek's (1984) study of a religious order that explores the relationship between organization members' interpretive schemes and organization structure; and Cunliffe's (in press) exploration of how managers act as practical authors of present and possible future organizational realities through their conversations. All of these studies highlight the way in which meaning making or interpretive activities construct and shape organizational and management realities.

The postmodern paradigm

The term postmodern was initially popularized in the arts, literary criticism and philosophy. Parker (1992) suggests that postmodernism was expressed in the architectural profession in proposals that architectural design

eschew monolithic modern structures in favor of design that displayed characteristics that challenged such convention. Designs which took traditional concepts of buildings and reinterpreted them, for example, by laying them on their sides, or turning them upside down, or fracturing them, or... were to be encouraged. Best and Kellner (1997) take the 'radical intellectuals of the 1960s' (for example, Michel Foucault, Jacques Derrida, Jean-Francois Lyotard, and Jean Baudrillard) as the first postmodern theorists, linking their ideas to the social upheaval taking place in France and the United States during the 1960s. Best and Kellner (1997) suggest that experiences of such social upheaval, for example, protests against the Vietnam war in the United States and the protests in France when students and workers occupied universities and factories, forcing then President de Gaulle to flee 'to come up with a solution', produced an openness to notions of discontinuity and rupture.

Today, a huge variety of ideas are submitted to the label 'postmodern' and, to touch on what will be a recurrent theme, it is not one school. As the previous discussion of the moment of double crisis indicated, though, a recurrent interest in postmodern work is in examining how power relations privilege particular world views while silencing others. The question of 'truth' is to be answered by disclosing which or whose truth is true! Not surprisingly, one dimension of postmodern thinking focuses on the problematic nature of scientific activity. Here, postmodernism argues for a basic rejection of the notion that science can be viewed as objective or value free because the assumptions underlying scientific activity and the projects in which scientists engage are always set by the wider culture, politics, values, and historical period in which they are embedded. Science is, therefore, understood to be a practical accomplishment achieved by scientists as a community (Hassard, 1990).

Postmodernism directly challenges the modernist research aim of achieving general, integrated, explanatory and predictive frameworks with its own view of knowledge as fundamentally fragmented and unstable. Furthermore, expectations that what is understood as knowledge can be integrated into a unified whole are not only questionable, they are also viewed as a kind of intellectual imperialism that ignores the fundamental instability of 'reality' (Hatch, 1997; Parker, 1992). Postmodernism suggests that what is taken for 'reality' is constructed by the discursive or language systems put in play by a particular social historical context - what is 'real' then is what is represented as such. And, researchers' own attempts at uncovering 'reality' should also be seen as forms of discourse (Parker, 1992). Indeed, postmodern theory has as one of its aims the deconstruction of grand narratives of truth and knowledge (Kincheloe and McLaren, 1994). Accordingly, a discernible focus of postmodern research attention has been the scientific 'authoritative' text, and, more specifically, researchers have attended to the way in which 'truth effects' are achieved via textual strategies (Lin-

stead, 1993).

With this highly problematic notion of discourse, not surprisingly postmodernists focus attention on power interests - whose voices have a place and whose voices are excluded - in current knowledge making practices. For many postmodern investigators, therefore, research is a political act and diversity and pluralism are central themes in their work. Research activity in this paradigm frequently draws on literary criticism and especially on the close deconstructive reading advanced by Derrida (1978) to investigate the textual construction of 'truth' and 'reality.' Examples of such work in management and organization studies include: Calas and Smircich's (1990) work, which examines organizational theorizing on leadership, drawing on feminist deconstructive strategies to highlight the cultural influences and constraints on this 'knowledge;' Martin's (1990) explication of gender conflict in an organization's response to the maternity leave of one of its female officers; Boje's (1995) account of the multiple and suppressed realities that constituted Disney; and Covalleski et al.'s (1998) use of Foucault's ideas about power and knowledge to describe how mentoring and management by objectives serve as techniques of control. In these works, the notions of multiple, disparate realities, power, and suppressed voices are thematic.

From the perspective of each of these three paradigms, Hatch (1997) indicates that organization studies can take on quite different meanings and methods. From the standpoint of modernism, organization studies would be the investigation of objective realities to be explained and controlled through the application of impartial rational and precise methods, hence the favoring of mathematically informed methods. From the interpretive vantage, management and organization studies would involve the study of those symbolic processes through which subjective experiences of organization are created; such a study is best achieved through methods like participant observation and ethnographic interviewing that take the researcher close to the experiences of those she studies. And, from the perspective of postmodernism, organization studies would take as their subject organization theory and the theorizing practices of their scholars as well as the organizational theories and ideologies of actors. Consequently, methods imported from literary theory, such as deconstruction and criticism, are favored as well as the critical approaches of Marxism and feminist theory (Hatch, 1997).

Locating grounded theory in moments and paradigms

What then of grounded theory? In which historical moment did it appear and within what paradigm is it situat-

ed? In their historically oriented framework, Lincoln and Denzin place *The Discovery of Grounded Theory* in the second modernist phase of qualitative research. Indeed, they identify it as one of several monographs that attempted to bring more formalization and systematization to qualitative methods during the post war years (Denzin and Lincoln, 1994). Certainly, there is much in the original monograph that expresses the realist concerns of the modernist time period in which it was written and that invites readers to locate the research approach with the modernist research paradigm. Indicators of a modernist perspective are carried forward into the originator's subsequent methodological texts. For example, the recurrent use of language terms such as 'emergence' and 'discovery' and theory grounded in 'reality' in the original monograph are strongly suggestive of an objective realist perspective. And, in this decade, there is an expressed concern with such modernist criteria as verifying hypotheses, the replicability of findings, and researcher bias (Corbin and Strauss, 1990; Strauss and Corbin, 1994).

On the other hand, grounded theory's concern with subjective experience stemming, as we shall shortly discuss, from its heritage in American pragmatism and the symbolic interactionist school of sociology, suggests that the grounded theory approach might be more appropriately located within the interpretive paradigm (Lowenberg, 1993). Over the years, the concerns articulated in the interpretive moment do enter into the originators' methodological discussions, and many claims do take on the language associated with interpretivism. For example, Strauss and Corbin (1994: 280) state that 'grounded theory requires that the interpretations and perspectives of actors on their own and others' actions become incorporated into our own [meaning researcher] interpretations.' Interestingly, Strauss (1987) had commented that as regards the disparate perspectives of knowledge as science, as compared with a view of knowledge in more humanistic terms, his position lay somewhere between.

Clearly, the paradigm lines are not always clearly drawn. When they are, they are determined more by the commitments of individual researchers than by the operational practices of a research approach. Thus, the grounded theory style has subsequently been used by Glaser and Strauss' students and others in more wholly interpretive studies (e.g. Charmaz, 1990) and also in feminist theorizing (Henwood and Pidgeon, 1995; Keddy et al., 1996). In management and organization studies, the approach has been invoked in works that are modernist in their orientation (e.g. Eisenhardt, 1989a; Kram and Isabella, 1985; Rafaeli and Sutton, 1991; Ross and Staw, 1993), in works that fall within the interpretive paradigm (Gephart, 1993; Gioia and Chittipeddi, 1991; Locke and Golden-Biddle, 1997; Prasad, 1993; Turner, 1976), and also in postmodern approaches (Covaleski et al., 1998).

Management and organization's diverse communities of qualitative research practice

The different paradigms just discussed do not account for all of the diversity in qualitative research within management and organization studies. Besides working from different research paradigms, qualitative investigators also work in various approaches or styles that reflect their orientation to particular communities of research practice. Three such communities that are significantly represented among qualitative researchers are ethnography, action research and case work. Before moving on to outline their distinguishing characteristics, a word of caution is perhaps in order. Drawing distinctions and boundaries between one area of inquiry and another is always slippery work because it requires a reduction and simplification of the research style of different communities of research practitioners. Within those particular communities, whether they are 'action researchers,' 'case researchers,' 'ethnographers,' or 'grounded theory researchers,' individuals may have as much that is different about their particular research practices as they have in common. Indeed, within each of the communities of practice that I shall touch on below, there are schools of thought and practice that represent modern, interpretive, and postmodern interpretations of the research act and its resultant research products.

Similarly, across different research practice communities, researchers may share much in terms of their general methodological procedures. Indeed, the particular constraints created by all qualitative work, such as the need to collect a data set, to fracture it for manipulation, somehow to label and reorder the fractured elements, and so on, mean that the overall shape of qualitative data analysis will be quite similar (Turner, 1988) regardless of the community with which qualitative researchers may identify.

Consequently, it is with this in mind that I wearily consider the distinguishing characteristics of other approaches or styles that fall under the umbrella of qualitative research and that are widely used within the domain of organization studies.

Action research

Action research in America is largely associated with the work of Kurt Lewin, who was interested in directing scientific approaches to improving the major social problems of the times, such as racism and social unrest

(Lewin, 1951). Lewin insisted that combining 'action' and 'research' was methodologically sound, arguing that an understanding of a social system could best be achieved by first introducing change into it and then observing its effects. At about the same time in the United Kingdom (shortly after World War II), there was a move towards this form of research by a group of scholars who later were to form the Tavistock Institute for Human Relations (Elden and Chisolm, 1993). The action research practice community is generally distinguished by two commitments: a commitment to learning by attempting to bring about some form of organizational transformation and a commitment to involving in the research and change process those organizational members likely to be affected. Consequently, action researchers attend to executing research processes that are relevant both for scholars interested in creating knowledge and for practitioners struggling with particular sets of problems (Baburoglu and Ravn, 1992). It distinguishes itself as a methodological approach in its dual purposes of providing practical advice and advancing knowledge.

To achieve this, action researchers deliberately aim to contribute to two domains. In the organizational community in which they are temporarily involved, action researchers actively participate in the very phenomenon they are studying in order to develop the organizational competencies of individual organizational actors (Susman and Evered, 1978), to develop the learning capacities of the organization as a whole (Argyris and Shon, 1978), and thereby to influence the course of events (Gummesson, 1991). In the professional scholarly community in which they are ongoing members, they intend to advance understanding of the change process and of the possibilities for organization.

As a research approach, action research is generally conceived as a cyclical and multi-phased inquiry process. It begins with problem diagnosis, progresses to the planning and design of action steps, carries forward with their implementation, and pauses with a subsequent evaluation of outcomes that will inform further diagnosis (Elden and Chisolm, 1993). One of the classic studies exhibiting this research approach is Coch and French's (1948) action research experiment at Harwood manufacturing, a pajama plant in Marion, Virginia. Coch and French were interested in exploring why the young women who worked in the plant resisted changes to improve operations. Their study began with a series of observations about the behavior of changed groups in order to devise a working theory that would account for the phenomenon of resistance. On the basis of their theory, which focused on resistance to change as an outcome of frustration and group induced forces, they designed and conducted a real life experiment in the factory. Their experimental manipulation focused on the effect that group participation in designing change might have on behavior. Its status as a field experiment was underscored in the creation of not only experimental but also control groups who were

denied the opportunity to participate in the design of their work, and the development of a set of measures by which the outcomes of the manipulation might be gauged.

Over the years, the basic commitments of the action research community have evolved and today there are many forms of action research practice. In 1993 the journal *Human Relations* devoted a special issue to exploring varieties of action research. One form of action research that has gained increasing attention is termed 'co-operative inquiry' (Reason, 1988, 1994; Reason and Heron, 1986). Co-operative inquiry focuses largely on individual rather than organizational change, and it has its roots in humanistic psychology's contention that individuals can, with support, choose to transform how they live their lives (Reason, 1994). The extension of action research's commitment to involving organization members in the research and change process involves them as full partners in the research and change process. This form of action research aims to make change and learning a self-generating process in those systems in which action researchers engage. The action researchers' goals, therefore, are not only to deal with specific problems, but to leave their subject partners with higher levels of self-determination and self-development (Elden and Chisolm, 1993).

Case studies

Widely used within organizational studies, case studies are perhaps the most difficult research approach to distinguish at this time. For example, characterizations of case studies as a research strategy that 'focuses on dynamics present within single settings' (Eisenhardt, 1989b: 534) or that is distinguished by its 'attempts to examine a contemporary phenomenon in its real life context' (Yin, 1981: 59) overlap considerably with all other naturalistically oriented qualitative research approaches. Post and Andrews, for example, acknowledge that 'case research is often a euphemism for qualitative research' (1982: 18). Ragin (1992) confirms that despite the centrality of case studies to social scientific talk and their widespread use, case analysis is poorly defined - or, perhaps a better statement would be that it is pluralistically defined. Thus, he points out that cases may be conceived as empirical units or as theoretical constructs - as inputs to or outcomes from the investigative process. And, Wolcott comments that when he tried to locate case studies with other styles of qualitative research, it appeared 'to fit everywhere in general and yet nowhere in particular' (1992: 36); consequently, he chose to regard case studies as a research product, a format for reporting qualitative descriptive work.

Indeed, to the extent that I dare risk a definition of the case study, I find compelling Stake's statement that 'case study is not a methodological choice, but a choice of object to be studied' (1994: 236). Case studies, therefore, are distinguished by the researcher's interest in studying particular objects - or bounded systems. According to Post and Andrews (1982), the object to be studied can be: a single or several organizations, for example, a business firm; one or more organizational sub-units, for instance, strategic business units; a particular organizational practice like strategic decision making; and one or more industries where the research might focus on competitors and producers of substitute goods or services. In studies of organization and management, investigations that describe themselves as case studies, generally focus on macro, organizational or industry levels of analysis. Most organization theorists would agree that Lawrence and Lorsch's (1967) study of organization and environment is a 'classic' in case study research within this domain.

Stake (1994, 1995) describes three types of case study. The first type, the intrinsic case study, focuses on the uniqueness of a particular case; analysts are interested simply in understanding the case itself - this particular organization - for all its particularity and uniqueness. By contrast, in the second type of case study, instrumental cases, researchers are interested in a particular case because of the potential it has to offer in providing insight into a substantive issue or to advance theory. When instrumental case studies extend into the study of more than one case, they become collective studies. The Lawrence and Lorsch (1967) study was of this type. They studied 10 organizations within a single industry (Lawrence, 1981). This third form of case study is more recently in Yin's (1994) approach to case study research, an approach now favored by several organization researchers working in the modern paradigm. Accordingly, Yin's approach assumes that researchers can objectively establish the facts of a particular case, that research ought to be theory-driven, and that multiple case studies should be designed around the kind of 'replication' logic found in the design of scientific experiments (Yin, 1998).

Regardless of the type of case study, the case approach does not favor any particular type of information - qualitative or quantitative. For example, the well-known Aston Studies included quantitative as well as qualitative data. Researchers in this program employed many measures that varied in type, sophistication and complexity to examine organizational structure and context (Pugh, 1988). Similarly, in the study of organization and environment, Lawrence and Lorsch's data derived from interviews with senior executives, a number of questionnaire based instruments and various economic indicators (Lawrence, 1981).

In terms of analytic strategies, case studies do seem to share the practice of producing a first-order, factually

based descriptive account (Van Maanen, 1979) - the case - of the units that are studied. Frequently, some form of analysis is then applied to those accounts (e.g. Brown and Eisenhardt, 1997). The procedures through which the gathered interview, observational, and quantitative data are reduced to fashion such accounts, however, are not always clear and do not seem to be codified.

To the extent that case studies are distinguished by the researcher's choice of an investigative object - issues of sampling are of central concern. Lawrence (1981) explains that the particular 10 organizations were selected for the organization and environment study in order to maximize differences in business environment and economic performance for the organizations. The can industry was selected because of its stability. Choice of the case or cases for study, in this and other case study researches, reflects purposeful sampling - that is the selection of cases that provide the opportunity to learn a great deal about issues central to the research (Patton, 1990). Patton (1990) offers some 15 different strategies to help the researcher think about the process of purposefully selecting information rich cases; some of these include sampling of deviant cases, sampling for maximum variation, and sampling for a specific criterion. Similarly, others suggest that selection may focus on a single site or a collection of sites; it may involve multiple settings within a site selection; it may be focused on a particular issue; it may focus on the ordinary or typical, or it may focus on the unusual (Stake, 1995; Yin, 1994).

Ethnography

Modern ethnography is conventionally traced to the social and cultural anthropologist's move towards collecting first-hand data on the social life of particular cultures. It is a form of qualitative research usually associated with the disciplines of sociology and anthropology. Typically, the term ethnography refers both to a research process and also to a research product - a cultural portrait of the social system studied (Agar, 1980; Hammersley and Atkinson, 1983). While there is, unsurprisingly, no unanimity as to the definition of ethnography, in practice it does have a number of distinguishing features (Atkinson and Hammersley, 1994; Hammersley and Atkinson, 1983).

Ethnography emphasizes the detailed examination of the nature of particular social phenomena in a very small number of settings; it is not unusual for ethnographic research to be conducted in just one social system. In the social system, ethnographers are committed to being present to the social situation studied as it un-

folds, and they attend to the mundane, to the routine, daily habits of mind and behavior (Fetterman, 1998). Researchers interact with those they study primarily through participant observation and unstructured interviewing, creating a set of field notes as their main data documents. They also examine any documents or records that become relevant to the study.

Typically, ethnographers begin data collection without a predetermined set of analytic categories, and focus more narrowly as the study proceeds. Hammersley and Atkinson (1983) refer to this as ethnography's 'funnel' structure - that is its focus narrows over the study. Accordingly, conceptual elements are more likely to be derived from researchers' experience in the field than to be taken into it (Wolcott, 1992). Ethnographic research is further distinguished by the extended period of time that researchers spend in the field. In organization studies, most researchers who refer to their work as 'ethnographic' have made commitments to spend one year in the participant observer role where they take part in the life of the organization and are present to the situations they study (e.g. Barley, 1990; Kunda, 1991). Van Maanen (1998) has discussed this in terms of the need for researchers to be present for an annual cycle within the social system studied and to have invested sufficient time in the setting so that they have learned and are able to comport their behavior to its particular cultural rules. At this point, they can claim to have learned and understood a portion, at least, of the habits of mind and action of members of the social system studied.

For the most part, these research practices are consistent with most field studies. But, as I noted earlier, the term ethnography refers to both a research process and a research product. In the end, ethnographers are distinguished from other field-based researchers by their commitment to produce culturally focused descriptions and interpretations from their experience, enquiry and examination in the field (Wolcott, 1980, 1992).

Grounded theory overlaps to a degree with all of these approaches to qualitative research. While grounded theorists generally do not share action researchers commitments to organizational transformation or to partnering with research subjects in the inquiry process, they are interested in developing theoretical elements that are useful to practitioners in the settings studied, providing them some understanding and control over situations they encounter on a daily basis (Glaser and Strauss, 1967). The originators' studies and theorizing on awareness and dying in medical settings played a role in changing communication practices in those settings. As an approach, though, grounded theory probably has more in common with case studies and with ethnography. Grounded theory shares with more ethnographic approaches a reserved and modest stance towards existing theory and a style of analysis that interweaves data collection and theory building so that, as

the research progresses, the analyst successively redefines and narrows her focus of study. However, whereas generally ethnographers are interested in understanding as much as possible about the cultural aspects of the contexts they enter as researchers, grounded theorists may not be so culturally oriented.

Similarly, the grounded theory style of handling and interpreting data may be incorporated into case studies. Post and Andrews (1982) explicitly advocate the grounded theory style of comparative analysis for case study research. And, as I'll discuss later in the book, the grounded theory style of data interpretation has been blended with the case study design and with ethnographic approaches to produce adaptations of this approach to qualitative research.

In closing, this chapter has underscored the extensiveness and the plurality of research perspectives that are expressed in the history, the investigative paradigms, and the research styles of communities of qualitative researcher practitioners. Note, though, that although I have devoted some attention to action research, case studies and ethnography, I have said little about ethnomethodology (Garfinkel, 1967), semiotics (Barley, 1983; Eco, 1976; Manning, 1987), deconstruction (Calas, 1992; Calas and Smircich, 1992; Derrida, 1976, 1978; Kilduff, 1993; Martin, 1990) or discourse and narrative analysis (Bruner, 1991; Burke, 1969; O'Connor, 1996; Phillips and Brown, 1993) as traditions and communities of research practice which have also found expression in management and organizational qualitative research. Many of these approaches are representative of closer ties between the humanities and social sciences, as the flowering of literary theory and cultural studies (begun during the moment of blurred genres) has attracted the interest of scholars in the social sciences (Grant and Fine, 1992). Management and organization scholars, too, have explored these humanities centered areas of concern and their accompanying investigative approaches. The domain of qualitative research is indeed plural if not somewhat confusing to the newcomer.

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